

LOCATION

The Great Sandy is north of the Gibson Desert. The Tanami slopes east into the Davenport Murchison Ranges.

INDIAN
OCEAN

Port Hedland
Karratha

Great Sandy
Desert

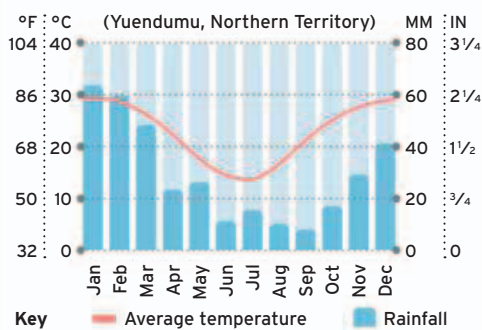
Tanami
Desert

Alice Springs

0 km 500
0 miles 500

CLIMATE

Annual rainfall is 14 in (350 mm) in the east, reducing westward. Average high temperatures are 86°F (30°C), average lows 61°F (16°C).



Fat-tailed dunnart

Sminthopsis crassicaudata

Despite its mouselike appearance, the fat-tailed dunnart is a marsupial that mainly feeds on insects, but also eats small lizards. Found in habitats ranging from open woodland and grassland to desert, these nocturnal mammals conserve energy by huddling in communal nests built under logs or rocks during colder weather; they can also enter a state of torpor for up to a few days when food is short.



pointed
snout

- ↔ 2–4 in (5–10 cm)
- ⚖ 3/8–3/4 oz (10–20 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐛 Moths, beetles, lizards
- 🏠



Australia

< FAT STORE

A dunnart's tail holds excess fat, which supplies it with energy when food is scarce.

Southern marsupial mole

Notoryctes typhlops

Southern marsupial moles resemble true moles, but belong to a separate order, Notoryctemorphia. These underground dwellers are effectively blind, with vestigial eyes, and also lack external ears. They do not use tunnels; instead, the soil collapses behind them as they move forward.



creamy yellow
to golden fur



- ↔ 5–7 in (13–18 cm)
- ⚖ 1–2 oz (28–57 g)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🐛 Small reptiles, insects, grubs
- 🏠



Australia

< DIGGING FOR DINNER

A horny nose-shield, rigid neck, and huge, spadelike foreclaws allow southern marsupial moles to power through sandy soil in search of food.

SPIKY SHELTERS
Hugely important for so many arid Australian habitats, spinifex sends roots down 7 ft (2.1 m) or more for moisture. In doing so, it stabilizes wind-whipped sand and provides food and shelter for a myriad of small creatures.

A rich haven for lizards

SPIKIFEX GRASS